

Storing Drone Footage Safely

Best-practice guide for secure storage of footage containing personal data

Covers encryption • Access control • Retention periods • Deletion protocols



As a drone operator, the footage you capture may contain personal data — faces, vehicle plates, home addresses and more. Under the Australian Privacy Act 1988, you are required to store this data securely, limit access, and delete it when no longer needed. This guide outlines practical steps to keep you compliant and your clients' data safe.

WHY IT MATTERS

A data breach involving personal data captured by your drone can result in:

- Penalties of up to \$50M (body corporate) or \$2.5M (individual) under the Privacy Act
- Loss of client trust and reputational damage
- OAIC investigation and mandatory remediation

1 Use Encrypted Storage

Encryption scrambles your footage so it is unreadable without the correct decryption key.

Cloud Storage

- Use services with end-to-end encryption
- Enable two-factor authentication (2FA)
- Verify the provider stores data in Australia
- Recommended: Google Workspace, Microsoft 365, AWS S3
- Never use free personal accounts for client footage

Encrypted External Drives

- Use hardware-encrypted drives (AES-256)
- Enable BitLocker (Windows) or FileVault (Mac)
- Always eject and lock drives when not in use
- Store drives in a locked cabinet or case
- Never leave drives unattended in vehicles

ENCRYPTION TIP

AES-256 is the gold standard encryption algorithm used by governments and banks worldwide.

If your drive or laptop is lost or stolen, AES-256 encryption makes your footage unreadable to thieves.

2 Limit Access to Authorised Personnel Only

Controlling who can view, edit or download your footage is a core Privacy Act obligation.

Role	Access Level	What They Can Do
Drone Operator	Full access	View, edit, export, delete
Video Editor	Project access	View and edit assigned footage only
Client	Delivery files only	View final deliverable — no raw footage
Third-party vendors	None by default	Must be granted per-project in writing

Implementing Role-Based Access Control (RBAC)

- Use folder-level permissions in cloud storage (not shared links)
- Revoke access immediately when a team member leaves a project
- Audit access logs monthly — most cloud platforms log all access events
- Document all access grants and revocations in your project file

3 Set and Enforce Retention Periods

The Privacy Act requires you to keep personal data only as long as reasonably necessary.

Data Type	Recommended Retention	Notes
Raw flight footage	30 days post-project	Unless contractually required longer
Edited / delivered files	Per client contract	Typically 1–3 years
Pre-flight checklists	7 years	Legal compliance record
Consent forms	7 years	Must outlive the footage
Access logs	2 years	Cloud platforms often auto-retain
Agronomic / survey data	Per engagement letter	May be commercially sensitive
News / documentary rushes	Per editorial policy	May be subject to legal hold

BEST PRACTICE

Build retention periods into your client contracts before the job starts.
A simple clause: "Raw footage will be deleted 30 days after final delivery unless otherwise agreed in writing."

4 Delete Footage Securely and on Schedule

Deleting a file does not erase it — it just removes the reference. Secure deletion is different.

How to Delete Securely
Local files: Use Eraser (Windows) or Secure Empty Trash (Mac) for physical overwrites
Cloud storage: Empty the recycle bin / trash folder — deletion is not instant otherwise
SD cards: Use a dedicated secure-erase tool; a simple format is not sufficient
Backups: Delete from ALL backup locations — including auto-sync folders like OneDrive

Deletion Workflow — Step by Step

- 1. Review footage after each project
- 2. Flag clips no longer needed for delivery
- 3. Confirm with client that delivery is accepted
- 4. Run secure delete on raw files
- 5. Delete from all cloud and backup locations
- 6. Log deletion date and method in your project file
- 7. Confirm consent forms and checklists are retained

End-of-life drives: Use DBAN or physical destruction for end-of-life drives

ACTION ITEM Schedule a monthly "footage audit" in your calendar to review and delete files on schedule.
Keep a simple deletion log: project name, deletion date, method used, and who authorised it.

5 Quick Reference Summary

Encrypt

- AES-256 for local drives
- End-to-end for cloud
- 2FA on all accounts
- Lock drives when not in use

Control Access

- Role-based permissions
- No shared download links
- Revoke on project end
- Audit logs monthly

Delete on Schedule

- Raw footage: 30 days
- Secure erase — not just delete
- Remove from all backups
- Log every deletion

Legal Reminder
Under APP 11 of the Australian Privacy Act 1988, you must take reasonable steps to protect personal information from misuse, interference, loss, and unauthorised access. Failure to do so may result in an OAIC investigation and significant financial penalties. These practices form your reasonable steps.